

An individual is distressed by her attraction to her supervisor. As a result, she acts coldly toward her supervisor and regularly tells her colleagues how much she despises her supervisor. This response is best characterized as which of the following, according to psychoanalytic theory?

- ☐ A. Displacement [19%]
- ☐ B. Rationalization [2%]
- ☐ C. Projection [15%]
- ✔ ☒ D. Reaction formation [62%]

Correct

63% answered correctly

Explanation:

Psychoanalytic theory: major defense mechanisms (incomplete list)

Denial	Refusing or being unable to recognize unacceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, insisting one is not angry when actually angry)
Projection	Attributing unacceptable thoughts/behaviors to someone or something else (eg, calling the sidewalk "stupid" after tripping)
Rationalization	Making excuses for unacceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, justifying cheating because "the course is impossible")
Regression	Behaving as if much younger to avoid unacceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, moving back in with parents to avoid personal responsibilities)
Repression	Blocking unacceptable thoughts/behaviors from consciousness (eg, being unaware of a traumatic past experience)
Displacement	Taking out unacceptable thoughts/behaviors on a safe target (eg, punching a pillow when angry at parents)
Sublimation	Transforming unacceptable thoughts/behaviors into acceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, taking up boxing as a way to channel one's anger)
Reaction formation	Behaving in a manner opposite unacceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, expressing love for a person one despises)

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According to psychoanalytic theory, **defense mechanisms** are a largely **unconscious** means of **dealing** with **anxiety** or **stress**, often through **distorting** or **ignoring** aspects of **reality**.

Some defense mechanisms are more adaptive (eg, directing unacceptable impulses into socially acceptable behaviors) and provide an effective means of coping with stress, whereas others are less adaptive (eg, avoiding feelings through drug use) and can result in additional problems (eg, job loss).

Reaction formation occurs when individuals outwardly express the opposite of how they actually feel when those thoughts and feelings are distressing. An individual whose attraction causes her distress is exhibiting reaction formation by outwardly expressing the opposite of attraction (eg, acting coldly) toward her supervisor.

(Choice A) Displacement involves taking out one's unacceptable thoughts and behaviors on another person or object. If this individual were employing displacement, she might exhibit attraction toward a peer rather than her supervisor (eg, "I feel attracted to my coworker").

(Choice B) Rationalization involves making excuses to oneself and to others for one's unacceptable thoughts and behaviors. If this individual were employing rationalization, she would justify or excuse her attraction to her supervisor (eg, "I'm vulnerable right now because of my recent divorce").

(Choice C) Projection involves attributing one's unacceptable thoughts and behaviors to others. If the individual were employing projection, she would ascribe her feelings to

someone else, such as to her supervisor (eg, "My supervisor is obviously attracted to me").

Educational objective:

In psychoanalytic theory, defense mechanisms are the largely unconscious means by which reality is altered (eg, distorted, ignored) to relieve anxiety or stress.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

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System:

Motivation, Emotion, Attitudes, Personality, and Stress